

Interest-holder perspectives on nutrition-related language in Australian schools: implications for children's understanding and relationship with food
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INTRODUCTION

Australian primary school children consume about one-third of their daily energy at school, making schools an important setting for nutrition education [1]. Children receive formal and informal nutrition messages at school through the curriculum, school practices, and everyday food experiences [2]. While food and nutrition education is included within the Australian Curriculum, it is not mandated as a discrete subject and may be implemented variably across schools. Health education has been linked as a disordered eating trigger [3], yet teachers report limited confidence and training [4], and Australian research on school nutrition-related language practice remains limited [5]. This study explored interest-holder perspectives on the use of nutrition-related language in Australian primary and secondary schools, and its potential impacts for children's understanding and relationship with food.

METHODS

A qualitative descriptive study used purposive and snowball sampling to recruit Australian professionals with expertise in education, nutrition, public health, child health, and policy. Semi-structured 45-minute interviews were conducted via Zoom using an 11-question interview guide informed by the literature and refined with the research team. Interviews were audio-visually recorded and transcribed. Data were analysed inductively using reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke), supported by NVivo [6].

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Nineteen professionals from education, health, research, and community sectors were interviewed. Data analysis is underway. Preliminary findings indicate interest-holders support less judgemental nutrition communication but differed on appropriate terminology, implementation, and the timing of formal nutrition education. Terms such as "healthy," "nutritious," and "sometimes foods" evoked differing preferences among interest-holders, with some using these terms and others avoiding them. A Dietitian, a Public Health Nutrition Professional, and a Child Health Advocate stated they believed these terms were not appropriate for children. Interest-holders thought social media and fitness-related messaging complicated nutrition communication. They believed children and young people actively interpret nutrition messages, with interpretations influenced by developmental stage and individual circumstances. A dietitian noted, even neutral language could be

interpreted as judgemental, particularly by anxious or vulnerable children. Interest-holders perceived children and young people retaining binary good/bad distinctions despite efforts to use more neutral language. Interest-holders across most professional groups described children and young people's relationships with food as including social meaning, limited agency over food choices, and contradictory school food environments. Almost all interest-holders confirmed they believed guidance and training were necessary. All interest-holders indicated inadequate guidance for teachers: most reported no formal guidance or training existed, including all school-based participants, and few believed resources exist but are not reaching teachers.

Interest-holders differed in the terminology, timing of nutrition education, and approaches used, with differences apparent between colleagues within the same school and within the same profession. This demonstrates a lack of professional consensus regarding nutrition communication in schools. Teachers reported receiving no formal guidance and relying on personal experience, outdated knowledge from their own education, and personal networks to inform their nutrition communication.

CONCLUSIONS

Attaining consistent nutrition communication in schools will require professional agreement, which can then inform clear, implementable guidance. As schools reach nearly all children and young people, they offer an important opportunity to promote more consistent nutrition communication.

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